

Managing Arthritis at Work in the UK: Your Rights, Adjustmen

Managing arthritis while working in the UK. Learn about workplace adjustments, your legal rights under the Equality Act, Access to Work scheme and practical coping strategies.

By **Living With Arthritis Editorial Team** · Reviewed by **Clinical Advisory Panel** (HCPC-registered physiotherapy & rheumatology nursing input) · 2026-02-08 · livingwitharthritis.org.uk



*Professional woman with arthritis using ergonomic equipment at a modern UK office desk
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For the millions of people in the UK living with arthritis, managing the condition alongside employment presents unique challenges. Joint pain, stiffness, fatigue and

unpredictable flare-ups can make the demands of a typical working day feel overwhelming. Yet with the right adjustments, legal protections and strategies, most people with arthritis can continue to work successfully and enjoy fulfilling careers. This comprehensive guide explains your rights as an employee with arthritis in the UK, the adjustments available to you, and practical techniques for managing symptoms at work.

Your Legal Rights Under the Equality Act 2010

Arthritis is classified as a disability under the **Equality Act 2010** if it has a substantial and long-term adverse effect on your ability to carry out normal day-to-day activities. "Long-term" means it has lasted, or is likely to last, at least 12 months. Most forms of arthritis — including osteoarthritis, rheumatoid arthritis and psoriatic arthritis — will meet this definition.

What This Means for You

- Protection from discrimination — Your employer cannot treat you less favourably because of your arthritis, whether in recruitment, promotion, training or dismissal
- Reasonable adjustments — Your employer has a legal duty to make reasonable adjustments to remove disadvantages you face because of your condition
- Protection from harassment — Colleagues or managers cannot make offensive comments or create a hostile environment related to your disability
- Right to flexible working — All employees with 26 weeks' service can request flexible working, and employers must consider requests reasonably

Telling Your Employer

You are not legally obliged to tell your employer about your arthritis during recruitment. However, disclosing your condition — especially to your line manager and HR department — is usually beneficial because it triggers the duty to make reasonable adjustments, provides context for any absences or performance variations, allows your employer to support you proactively, and protects you more effectively if problems arise. Many people worry about stigma, but UK employment law strongly protects you once a disclosure is made. If you experience negative consequences after disclosing, you may have a claim for disability discrimination.

Reasonable Adjustments at Work



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Reasonable adjustments are changes your employer makes to ensure you can do your job effectively. What is "reasonable" depends on the size and resources of the employer, the cost, and the practicality of the adjustment. Common adjustments include:

Physical Workspace

- Ergonomic chair — A chair with lumbar support, adjustable height and armrests can significantly reduce pain
- Sit-stand desk — Alternating between sitting and standing prevents stiffness from prolonged positions

- Ergonomic keyboard and mouse — Split keyboards, vertical mice and trackballs reduce hand and wrist strain
- Voice recognition software — Dragon NaturallySpeaking can reduce typing if hand arthritis is severe
- Accessible parking — A closer parking space to reduce walking distance, especially in bad weather
- Ground-floor workspace — Avoiding stairs if knee or hip arthritis is problematic

Working Patterns

- Flexible start/finish times — Starting later allows morning stiffness to ease before commuting
- Working from home — Reducing commuting and providing a comfortable environment on difficult days
- Regular breaks — Short breaks every 30–45 minutes to move and stretch
- Reduced hours — Temporary or permanent reduction during flare-ups or medication changes
- Phased return — Gradually increasing hours after a period of absence

Task Modifications

- Reallocating physical tasks — Swapping heavy lifting or prolonged standing duties with colleagues
- Modified targets — Adjusting output expectations during flare-ups
- Additional time for tasks — Allowing extra time for activities affected by your condition
- Changed meeting formats — Virtual meetings to reduce travel; walking meetings for gentle movement

The Access to Work Scheme

Access to Work is a government programme that provides grants to cover the costs of workplace adjustments beyond what is considered "reasonable" for your employer. It can fund

specialist equipment (ergonomic furniture, assistive technology), support workers or job coaches, travel to work if public transport is difficult (taxi fares), mental health support, and communication support. To apply, visit the gov.uk website or call the Access to Work helpline on 0800 121 7479. The scheme is available to employees, self-employed workers and people starting a new job. Applications can be made at any time — you don't need to be starting a new role.

Practical Strategies for Managing Symptoms at Work



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Morning Routine

- Allow extra time in the morning for stiffness to ease — set your alarm 30 minutes earlier if needed

- Take a warm shower to loosen joints before dressing
- Do 5–10 minutes of gentle stretches before leaving the house
- Prepare your work clothes and bag the night before to reduce morning rushing
- Take any morning medications with breakfast to ensure they have time to work

During the Working Day

- Move regularly — Set a timer to remind you to stand, stretch or walk every 30–45 minutes
- Pace yourself — Alternate between demanding and less demanding tasks throughout the day
- Stay hydrated — Dehydration worsens stiffness; keep a water bottle at your desk
- Manage pain proactively — Don't wait until pain becomes severe; take medication at regular intervals as prescribed
- Use gadgets and aids — Jar openers, electric can openers, padded pen grips and lightweight equipment all reduce joint strain
- Protect your joints — Carry bags on your forearm rather than gripping with your hands; use both hands to carry heavy items

Managing Flare-Ups at Work

Have a flare-up plan agreed with your manager in advance. This might include working from home on bad days, access to a quiet rest room, permission to take additional short breaks, pre-agreed modified duties during flares, and clear communication channels so your team knows when you need support without lengthy explanations.

Occupational Health Assessments

Many UK employers offer occupational health services. An OH assessment involves a meeting with an occupational health professional who will assess how your arthritis affects your ability to work, recommend specific adjustments, advise on any limitations or concerns, provide your employer with a report (with your consent), and help plan any return to work after absence. You can request an OH referral through HR or your line manager, or your employer may suggest one. These assessments are confidential between you and the OH professional — your employer only receives the recommendations, not your full medical details.

Sickness Absence and Arthritis

If arthritis causes you to take time off work, remember that disability-related absences should be recorded separately from general sickness, they should not normally trigger absence management procedures or be counted towards absence thresholds, your employer should consider whether adjustments would reduce future absences, and you are entitled to Statutory Sick Pay (SSP) from the fourth day of absence. If you feel your employer is treating disability-related absences unfairly, seek advice from ACAS (0300 123 1100) or Citizens Advice.

Self-Employment and Freelancing

Many people with arthritis find self-employment offers greater flexibility. If you work for yourself, structure your day around your symptoms (e.g., working when stiffness has eased), build in rest days and buffer time for flare-ups, invest in ergonomic equipment, consider Access to Work for self-employed support, use technology to automate repetitive tasks, and set clear boundaries with clients about response times and deadlines.

Financial Support

- Personal Independence Payment (PIP) — For extra costs of living with a disability (not means-tested, available whether or not you work)
 - Employment and Support Allowance (ESA) — If you cannot work or have limited capability for work
 - Universal Credit — Work allowances may be higher if you have a health condition
 - Disabled Facilities Grant — For home adaptations that help you remain independent and able to work
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Getting Support

- Versus Arthritis — Employment advice line and guides at [versusarthritis.org](https://www.versusarthritis.org)
- ACAS — Free workplace advice including disability rights (0300 123 1100)

- Citizens Advice — Help with employment rights, benefits and adjustments
- Disability Rights UK — Factsheets and advice on employment and disability
- Your GP or rheumatologist — Can provide supporting letters for workplace adjustments

Working with arthritis is challenging but achievable. With the right adjustments, support and self-management strategies, you can maintain a productive and satisfying career. Don't hesitate to ask for help — it's your legal right. Our virtual assistant can provide personalised advice on workplace adjustments for your specific type of arthritis.

This article is for general information only. For specific legal advice about employment rights, contact ACAS or a qualified employment lawyer.

Q&A

Question: What is the key thing to know about managing arthritis at work in the uk: your rights, adjustmen?

Short answer: In the UK, arthritis is considered a disability under the Equality Act 2010 if it significantly affects daily activities for at least 12 months. This protects employees from discrimination and obliges employers to make 'reasonable adjustments', such as providing ergonomic equipment, flexible working hours, or modifying tasks. The Access to Work scheme also offers grants for workplace adjustments.

Question: When should I seek professional advice?

Short answer: If symptoms persist or worsen, pain is severe and unresponsive to usual relief, or you develop new symptoms, contact your GP, physiotherapist or rheumatology team promptly.

Question: Where can I get free arthritis support in the UK?

Short answer: Versus Arthritis: 0800 5200 520. NRAS: 0800 298 7650. Free tools and guides at livingwitharthritis.org.uk.